

Web 2.5 Manifesto — Why Axie Duel is the Future of Web3 Gaming

The problem with Web3 games today

Web3 games today fall into one of two extremes, and both lose players:

Extreme 1 — "Web3 first" (ledger-day-zero)

- **Examples:** most P2E games of 2021-2023.
- **Onboarding:** download a wallet → bridge tokens → buy starter NFT → KYC → play.
- **Friction:** 30+ minutes from "I heard about this game" to "first match".
- **Result:** 95% drop-off before first session. Only crypto natives survive.

Extreme 2 — "Web2 with cosmetic NFTs"

- **Examples:** Hearthstone with NFT skins, EA's "blockchain experiments".
- **Onboarding:** standard email login. NFTs are decorative, no gameplay impact.
- **Friction:** low onboarding, but NFT holders feel cheated — there's no real utility.
- **Result:** Web3 audience disengaged; the game becomes a Web2 game with a token tax.

The Web 2.5 thesis

Axie Duel is built for both audiences simultaneously, with no compromise on either side.

Layer	Web2 player journey	Web3 player journey
Onboarding	Sign in with Google in 5 seconds	Same Google sign-in (no wallet required day 1)
First match	Pick a competitive starter deck → play vs bot	Same path — wallet linking is optional, post-onboarding
Progression	Earn Dust (off-chain currency) → buy packs → build collection	Earn Dust + connect Ronin → unlock Axie NFTs as unique cards

Competitive	Climb ladder with starter + earned cards	Climb ladder + access Ranked Premium tier (NFT-gated for matchmaking quality, NOT power)
Tournaments	Free entry events (small prize pools)	AXS/SLP entry events (90 % players, 5 % burn, 5 % game treasury) — open to F2P with earned AXS
Identity	Username + avatar	Username + avatar + on-chain proof (wallet badge)

Both paths win. Web2 players never feel locked out. Web3 players have real, mechanically meaningful utility for their NFTs.

Comparison: how does this stack up against the genre?

Game	Onboarding	NFT utility	F2P viability
Axie Duel	5-sec Google login	NFTs → unique deterministic cards	Competitive starter, top ladder reachable F2P
Axie Origins (official)	Wallet required	High — Axies <i>are</i> the units	Limited free Axies; ranked requires NFT
Yu-Gi-Oh Master Duel	Email login	None (no Web3)	Strong F2P balance, but no Web3
Hearthstone	Email login	None	Decent F2P, no Web3
Pixels (Ronin)	Wallet required	Heavy NFT dependency	Limited F2P; high token reliance
Heroes of Mavia	Wallet required	NFT-locked progression	Locked behind NFT

The gap Axie Duel fills: a TCG with Master Duel-quality F2P AND deep Web3 utility. No one else is doing this in the Axie ecosystem.

Player journey: the 3 transitions

0 → Web2 player (Tuesday afternoon, casual gamer)

1. Sees a tweet: "Tactical TCG with Axie integration"

2. Opens <https://axie-duel.vercel.app> on phone or desktop
3. Clicks "Sign in with Google" — done in 5 seconds
4. Picks a starter deck (Plant / Bird / Beast)
5. Forced welcome tutorial (5 slides, 90 seconds)
6. First PvE match vs Novato bot — wins, earns Dust + XP
7. **Already a player.** No wallet, no tokens, no friction.

Web2 → Web3 curious (one week later)

1. Returning player has 1,500 Dust + 3 starter decks
2. Sees in dashboard: *"Connect Ronin Wallet to see your Axies as unique cards"*
3. Clicks → Waypoint OAuth (no seed phrase, MPC-based)
4. **Now a Web3 player.** Their Axies appear at `/my-axies` as cards with parts-derived stats and effects.
5. Optional: enters a tournament with their AXS to play for prizes (90 % players / 5 % burn / 5 % game treasury).

Web3 → power user / collector (one month later)

1. Buys 2-3 Axies on Mavis Marketplace specifically for their parts (rarer parts → distinctive card effects)
2. Mints unique game-card NFTs from our `AxieDuelCardNFT` contract for collectibility
3. Joins ranked tournaments. Wins Dust + AXS prizes.
4. **Drives demand for both AXS (entry fees + burn) and Axie NFTs (unique parts) on Mavis Marketplace.**

Why Sky Mavis benefits from Web 2.5 design

Player base expansion

- **Web2 friction is eliminated** → 10x more potential players reach first session.
- The current Axie audience is ~50k DAU (Origins). Web2.5 onboarding could 10-50x this.

NFT utility deepening

- Every Axie NFT becomes a playable card via deterministic algorithm.
- 3M+ Axies in circulation = 3M+ unique cards, no manual art needed.
- Demand for *specific parts* (not just "any Axie") creates Marketplace differentiation.

Player identity & progression

- Customizable hero avatar (9 class-themed presets, generated SVG, no external assets) + level-tier frames that grow more striking as you level up (Initiate → Ranger → Vanguard → Ascendant → Mythic). Bigger framed portrait + level badge shown live during battle.
- **Phase 2 (with Axie API access)**: a hero preset can be a real Axie from the wallet (sprite + parts), and an NFT-backed gold frame tier — turning the player portrait itself into Axie NFT utility.
- Full progression design (what leveling unlocks beyond cosmetics, and the hard contract of what it *never* unlocks — horizontal, never combat power):

[docs/PROGRESSION.md](#) .

Token sinks (deflationary pressure)

- Tournament entries split 5 % to permanent burn + 5 % to a transparent game treasury (10 % combined) per cycle.
- Pack openings burn 25% of AXS spent.
- Cosmetic permanent unlocks burn 100% of AXS.

Counter-narrative to pay-to-win

- Top ladder reachable F2P (validated by tournament bracket data post-launch).
- NFT cards are **side-grades**, not upgrades.
- This directly addresses the 2021 backlash that hurt Axie Infinity's image.

Risk mitigation

- Web2-only mode means the game survives even if regulatory/market headwinds slow Web3 adoption.
- Open source codebase means Sky Mavis can fork/inherit if the core team pivots — no platform lock-in risk.

Closing thesis

Web 2.5 is the bridge that takes the next 1M players into Web3. Axie Duel is built on this thesis from day one, with production-grade architecture, real NFT utility, deflationary token economy, and a balanced competitive design.

It is the kind of project that makes the **Builders Program ROI argument easy**: low friction acquisition + deep NFT integration + AXS/SLP burn + open codebase = exactly what Sky Mavis pillars demand.

"The future of Web3 gaming is not crypto-native — it's Web2-grade gameplay with Web3 ownership as a deepening choice. Axie Duel is the proof."